

Cover Letter

Li et al.

Dear Associate Editor,

We are pleased to submit our revised manuscript entitled

“Random effects on numbers-at-age transitions implicitly account for movement dynamics and improve stock assessment and management” (CJFAS-2025-0092).

We are grateful to you and the reviewers for the constructive feedback. We have carefully considered all comments and substantially revised the manuscript. The major revisions include:

- **Clarification of methods and equations**
- **Sensitivity analyses and robustness checks**
- **Model structure clarifications**
- **Revised figures and captions**
- **Improved conclusions and implications**

Minor edits were also made throughout the manuscript to correct wording, grammar, figure references, and reference formatting.

We believe these revisions have substantially strengthened the manuscript and improved its accessibility to a broader readership. We thank you again for your time and consideration, and we look forward to your assessment of our revised submission.

Sincerely,

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